

QUESTION 1

Wine 1

a) Grenache, McLaren Vale

The medium ruby colour and notes of wild strawberry, cherry and spice and medium yet slightly grippy tannins point to either Pinot Noir or Grenache as the variety. The alcohol 14.5% could be consistent with both but the acidity is more medium rather than high suggesting Grenache as most likely. The noticeable white pepper finish is also more consistent with Grenache.

The very pure, ripe and quite concentrated strawberry flavours indicate a high quality region for the variety, notably Barossa or McLaren Vale. The quite concentrated nature and pure red-fruited style are consistent with low yielding, old vines from both these regions but the acidity is a little more refreshing and lingering pointing to the slightly fresher, more ocean-influenced styles from McLaren Vale.

b)

The very pure strawberry fruited nature with no obvious herbaceous notes indicate all fruit was destemmed with no whole bunches. The preservation of these red fruited characters indicate fermentation in inert vessel, stainless steel or concrete for around 18 days at cool temperatures 20-24°C. The very subtle oak and vanilla notes indicate a likely combination of ageing in inert vessel, stainless steel, and some old oak puncheons, around 30%, for approximately 12 months.

c) A quite complex, fairly concentrated, spicy and pure-fruited style of Grenache. One that has the structure to hold in the medium term.

A good quality, likely Estate level style of Grenache which shows a core of pure strawberry fruit characters. There is complexity from the spicy, peppery nature from both varietal typicity and the light touch of oak during 12 months maturation. The wine shows a very good balance between the medium, smooth tannins, medium acidity and moderate fruit concentration and the finish too is medium. It lacks the extra concentration and length of a very good quality, single vineyard style pointing more towards a good quality Estate level example.

Wine 2

a) Cabernet Sauvignon, Margaret River

The dark ruby colour and quite pronounced notes of blackcurrant, menthol and eucalyptus suggest Cabernet Sauvignon or Cabernet Franc. The full body, high alcohol 14% and quite high and grippy tannins could be in line with both as is the high, crisp acidity. The more menthol character without any slight herbaceous note is, however, more consistent with Cabernet Sauvignon over Cabernet Franc and confirms this as the variety.

The quite fine-boned and elegantly tannic style with full body, 14% alcohol and quite long finish suggests a premium area such as Margaret River or Coonawarra. Both regions demonstrate this pure core of blackcurrant fruit but the menthol rather than pure peppermint character is more consistent with the herbal rather than minty styles of Coonawarra. The acidity though high is a little lower than found in the cooler reaches of Coonawarra and is more consistent with the warmer, temperate climate of Margaret River.

b) The high and quite rounded tannins together with the fairly deep ruby colour suggests fermentation for around 2 weeks at 26-28°C in inert vessel with regular pumpovers. The quite fine toast and fairly rich, rounded mouthfeel suggests ageing in French barriques, around 20% new, for 9 months.

c) A full bodied, yet elegant, finely balanced, herbal and oak aged style. A wine that is starting to evolve but will keep in the medium term.

A very good quality wine, likely Estate Level, as shown by the quite high concentration of blackcurrant fruit. The wine is extremely well balanced between the high, crisp acidity, quite high tannins, and quite pronounced fruit intensity. The alcohol of 14% is also very well integrated and

not obtrusive. There is complexity too from the fine toast and vanilla notes from new French oak ageing. The finish too is quite long but stops short of the best single vineyard or special cuvée styles all suggesting a very good quality, Estate Level example.

Wine 3

a) Pinot Noir, Tasmania, Australia

The pale ruby colour and pronounced notes of rose petals, strawberry, wild cherry and sweet spice immediately points to Pinot Noir. Grenache was also briefly considered as the tannins are moderate yet fine but the 13.5% alcohol and in particular the very high, racy acidity were too elevated for Grenache and are more consistent with Pinot Noir. The distinct herbal character and very pure juicy fruit also suggest a high proportion of whole bunch again more in line with Pinot Noir.

The quintessential, well-defined strawberry fruit characters and vanilla from some new French oak point to a high quality origin such as Yarra Valley, Mornington Peninsula or Tasmania. The 13.5% alcohol could be consistent with all three yet the distinct floral nature and very high, crisp acidity suggests an even cooler climate than both Yarra Valley and Mornington and points to Tasmania.

b) The very pure floral and red-fruited style with a distinct herbal and slightly spicy note suggest a high proportion of whole bunches, at least 50%, during fermentation. The very fine, elegant tannins point to gentle pigeage in open top fermenters at temperatures around 28-30° likely for 18 days. The very integrated fine toast and vanilla point to ageing in French oak barriques, approximately 30% new, for around 10 months.

c) A very fine, highly complex, whole bunch fermented and extremely elegant, cool climate style of Pinot Noir. One that will rival some top estates in Burgundy.

The extremely elegant strawberry fruit attack and very pure yet concentrated floral, wild cherry, and spicy notes point to a highly complex and outstanding quality wine. There is exquisite balance between the medium fine-grained tannins, high racy acidity and concentrated red fruit character. The wine is built on grace, elegance and poise rather than power and brute force and the finish is long all in line with the outstanding quality, equivalent to very good Village from Chambolle-Musigny or 1er Cru Volnay.

Wine 4

a) Barossa Valley, Shiraz, Australia

The deep opaque ruby colour, pronounced blueberry, black cherry and liquorice character immediately point to Shiraz. The very ripe black fruit characters, notes of menthol and eucalyptus with very high 15% alcohol, medium acidity, full body and quite high yet very ripe tannins point to a warm area and Barossa in particular. The quite high level of concentration, and distinct coconut from American oak and good quality all further confirm Barossa as the origin

b) The deep, opaque colour and structure of quite high yet very ripe and fine-grained tannins suggest fermentation in stainless steel at 25 - 28°C for around 16 days with regular pumpovers. The firm tannic structure indicates the likely blending free run with press wine. The quite overt coconut and vanilla notes indicate ageing in predominantly American oak, likely larger format used hogsheads and puncheons, for around 1 year to give this rounded and gently oxidative style.

C) A full bodied, intense, quite concentrated, high alcohol, approachable style of Shiraz. Good quality, Estate level, \$25. The wine shows quite a high concentration of black berry, and cooked fruit flavours. There is complexity from the coconut and dill notes from ageing in American oak. The wine still shows remarkable balance between the quite concentrated black fruit flavours, medium acidity and high 15% alcohol, medium yet lively acidity and pronounced fruit intensity. The length is medium all indicating a good quality, Estate level wine.

QUESTION 2

Wine 5

a) **St Emilion Grand Cru. Merlot/Cabernet Franc**

The deep opaque ruby colour and pronounced notes of plum, black cherry and clove point to a wine dominated by Merlot and suggest a Right Bank origin. There quite perfumed blackcurrant and camphor note suggests around 30% Cabernet Franc with further cassis notes indicating a possible complement, 10% of Cabernet Sauvignon. The high alcohol 14.5%, quite high and lively acidity and high but extremely plush tannins all further confirm a Merlot based wine and point to St Emilion or Pomerol as the likely origins. Whilst the high 14.5% alcohol could be consistent with both, Pomerol would have more grip with the tannins and there would be an underlying iron-rich mineral note absent in this wine, which is more chalky on the finish. It all suggests St Emilion Grand Cru as the the origin.

b) An excellent quality, Grand Cru Classé example.

The wine shows a wonderful attack of ripe, hedgerow and plummy fruit. There is a core of highly concentrated black fruit which is well balanced with the high 14.5% alcohol and quite high, refreshing acidity. Complexity too is present in the fine toast from new French oak aging and the finish is long. It all points to an outstanding Grand Cru Classé style. It lacks the super high intensity, finesse and very long length of the very best GCC A or B examples but is still outstanding quality nonetheless.

Wine 6

a) **Moulis, Médoc. Cabernet Sauvignon/Merlot/Petit Verdot**

The quite deep, ruby colour and combination of blackcurrant and black plum characters indicate a wine with a majority of Cabernet Sauvignon, 50%, but with a noticeable complement of Merlot 40% The 14.5% alcohol is consistent with this as is the high and quite refreshing acidity brought by the Cabernet. The tannins, though, are very high with significant grip suggesting quite a high proportion of Petit Verdot, likely 10%, in the blend. This all points to a Left Bank style. Although intense and quite concentrated it lacks the pure class and high quality of the 4 major communes and suggests either a very good Haut-Médoc or a satellite appellation such as Moulis or Listrac. The perfumed style and firm and yet quite rounded tannins are more in line with Moulis over the more austere styles found in the more inland and cooler area of Listrac-Médoc.

b) A very good quality, Cru Bourgeois Supérieur.

The wine shows complexity from the wide array of flavours from the 3 blended grape varieties with notes of blackcurrant, plum and peppery spice. It shows quite intense dark fruit concentration and the finish too is quite long. The tannins though high, are still in balance with the 13% alcohol, and high acidity. It lacks the precision of a Cru Classé style, the rounded tannins just edging into slightly coarse. Yet there is enough weight, intensity and quite long length to point to a very good quality Cru Bourgeois, likely Supérieur .

Wine 7

a) **St Julien. Cabernet Sauvignon/Merlot/Cabernet Franc**

The deep purple colour, pronounced nose of blackcurrant and black cherry immediately point to a very high proportion of Cabernet Sauvignon and a Left Bank Bordeaux. The very slight red fruit and plum note points to a complement, 14% of Merlot and the perfumed, fragrant finish indicate a probable small touch of Cabernet Franc 3%. The high yet very fine-grained tannins, 14% alcohol and high, vivacious acidity point to a high quality commune on the Left Bank, likely St Julien or Pauillac. It does not show the overt power or muscularity of Pauillac. The forward fruit nature and extremely enticing profile are more in line with the fragrant and very ripe styles of St Julien.

b) Exceptional quality, 2ème Grand Cru Classé

The wine shows a very high degree of blackcurrant and black cherry concentration. There is incredible balance between the 14% alcohol, high, tingling acidity and intense fruit concentration. The tannins, though high, are extremely powdery and fine-grained all testament to the excellent quality as is the very long finish. There is an effortlessness to the whole wine which carries

through to the persistent finish. Finally, it clearly has the capacity to age in the long term all pointing to a Grand Cru Classé of at least 2nd Growth Level.

c) 2022

The high alcohols, particularly 14.5% in Wine 5 and 14% in Wine 7 and deep ruby colour of all three wines with noticeable purple in wines 5 and 7 in particular suggest a recent warm, dry vintage such as 2020 or 2022. 2021 was immediately eliminated as this cooler year would have shown lower alcohols, leaner mouthfeels and higher acidity levels. The full body across all three wines, particularly Wines 5 and 7 are all consistent with the great vintages of 2020 and 2022 yet the high, plush nature of the tannins and distinct purple colours on Wine 5&7 are all consistent with the more recent and less evolved vintage of 2022.

The very tannic nature due to the high proportion of Petit Verdot in Wine 6 is also testament to a very warm and dry year to achieve ripeness with this typically difficult grape variety. The acidity levels too across all three wines from quite high in Wine 5 to high in Wines 6 and 7 are also consistent with this warm yet more even growing year and less drought affected Vintage than 2020. The oak, too, is very prominent on all wines, especially Wine 7 all indicating a young vintage, 2022.

Wine 5 with its predominantly ruby and purple colour is still very youthful. The wine shows a high level of black and red fruit concentration, the tannins are high yet very silky suggesting the wine will improve and develop tertiary characters over the next 6-8 years. During this time the oak will integrate further and the fruit open out more. It then has the weight and depth to keep for at least another 8-10 years beyond this all supported by these high tannins and quite high, fresh acidity.

Wine 6 shows less purple than both wines 5&7 but is still ruby with no trace of garnet. It still shows all primary characters of plum and blackcurrant and the vanilla from oak is present but less prominent than the other two wines. It still has enough depth and concentration to improve over the next 3-4 years especially supported by the high tannins and high acidity. The quite high intensity and at least 25% new French oak will allow further keeping for another 4-5 years before decline.

Wine 7 with its deep purple colour and very primary nose of blackcurrant and fine toast from a high proportion of new French oak is the least evolved wine of the three. The extremely high level of pure blackcurrant fruit and elevated and very fine-grained tannins suggest this wine will continue to improve over the next 12-15 years when the oak will integrate fully, tannins soften and fruit will open out further. The very intense concentration and weight together with these high tannins and lively acidity will then allow it to keep for at least another 20 years before fading.

QUESTION 3

Wine 8

a) The pale ruby/garnet colour and strawberry character with an earthy nature suggest suggests a thin skinned grape such as Pinot. The quite funky and slightly savoury animal note points to fermentation in inert vessel, concrete or stainless steel likely with natural yeast, for around 18 weeks at 25-28°C. The subtle tannins point to gentle extraction likely pigeage with no post fermentation maceration. The savoury profile and very gentle oxidative notes point to ageing in old oak vessel, likely large format 500 litres, for up to 18 months. The slightly animal and 'natural' style point to minimal SO₂ addition and probable bottling without fining or filtration.

b) A quite funky, savoury, "natural", low intervention style with minimal SO₂.

A very good quality wine that shows quite a high red fruit concentration that belies the very pale colour. There is complexity from the savoury, wild yeast notes and spiciness from likely whole bunch fermentation. It is well balanced between the high acidity and moderate tannins and the finish is quite long.

The quite complex and concentrated style with long oxidative ageing points to a wine selling for around \$40. This slightly bretty and minimal intervention style means it will appeal mostly to those natural wine lovers who love these off-beat and less clinical styles. The pale colour and gentle tannins mean it could also appeal to those looking for lower tannin red wines and could entice some Pinot Noir lovers. The funky style, whilst not appealing for some traditional wine drinkers, could also find favour with Sommeliers and Independent wine Merchants, particularly those

specialising in organic or natural wines. Likely to be most popular in cities like London, New York or Berlin where these wines are in fashion.

c) Pais, Itata

The very pale ruby colour, pure red-fruited character and slightly earthy and spicy note suggest Pais. The 14.5% alcohol, quite high acidity, moderate tannins and quite funky style are all consistent with this. The concentrated nature suggest an old vine example from Itata.

Wine 9

a) The moderate purple colour and red cherry character with 13% alcohol and quite low, soft tannins suggest a wine based on Gamay. The very juicy red fruit with candied and bubble gum notes indicate a wine made by carbonic maceration rather than conventional destemmed fermentation. The low, soft tannins suggest only a short ferment of around 10 days and the predominantly juicy fruited style with no obvious vanilla point to ageing in inert vessel, stainless steel or old oak cask for around 6 months before likely fining, filtration and bottling.

b) A very juicy, forward, low tannin, easy-drinking and carbonic style of wine. One intended more for early consumption rather than long term ageing.

Good quality, Villages level. The wine shows quite a vibrant core of cherry and strawberry fruit. It is still very juicy and candied from the carbonic maceration but there is slightly more depth and longevity on the finish, which is medium rather than short, all suggesting Villages over a straight generic Beaujolais example.

This quite forward yet slightly more intense Villages style suggests a wine retailing for around \$20. It is a step up from basic Beaujolais and so will appeal to those looking for slightly more structure than the very entry-level, candied and lighter bodied examples. It will still find favour with those consumers looking for lighter bodied and less astringent red wines and one with low tannins. It could be sold as a good starting point for new consumers moving on to red wines from white. Likely to be available in major supermarkets Monopolies and also on On Trade Chain wine lists due to its very versatile and approachable style.

c) Beaujolais-Villages

The bright juicy cherry fruit and candied characters from carbonic maceration point to Gamay and therefore Beaujolais. The 13% alcohol, high, crisp acidity, low tannins, slightly more intense style and medium finish indicate a Beaujolais Villages over a straight Beaujolais.

Wine 10

a) The medium ruby colour, very perfumed, fragrant nose of rose petals, dark cherry, plum and sweet spice point to a wine from Pinot Noir. The combination of a pure red fruited style with some herbaceous or peppery notes indicate quite a high proportion of whole bunches, 40%, together with destemmed fruit. The medium yet fine tannins point to gentle extraction likely by pigeage over around 25 days and fermentation likely with wild yeast in inert vessel at temperatures from 27-30°C. The complex notes of fine toast and vanilla with integrated smoke notes point to ageing in French oak barriques, 25% new, for around 12 months. The quite long, complex, savoury finish suggests no fining or filtration prior to bottling.

b) A very expressive, complex, silky, youthful yet age worthy style. One that would definitely improve in the medium term.

A very good quality, likely Single Vineyard example.

The wine shows a beautiful expressive nose with a high level of red fruit intensity. It is very complex with an array of aromas and flavours from rose petals to dark cherry and vanilla from some new French oak all contributing to the very good quality. There is an excellent balance between the high acidity, 14% alcohol and moderate tannins, which are fine and quite powdery. The finish is quite long, just stopping short of a longer length required for an outstanding example. It is still a step up from an Estate Level wine all suggest a very good, Single Vineyard style.

The quite concentrated and complex oak-aged style indicates a wine retailing for around \$55.

The very intense aromatic style suggests it will appeal to those consumers who love the most expressive and perfumed styles of Pinot Noir. The high acidity and quite firm tannins and vibrant

fruity nature suggest it offers a more powerful alternative to Village Level Côte d'Or Red Burgundy, and this combination of intensity and freshness a good substitute to other New World Pinot Noirs from Russian River to Hemel-en-Aarde. Likely to be popular in its local market but also in export markets such as Australia, UK, Canada and USA where demand for these high quality alternatives to more expensive Burgundy is strong.

c) Central Otago, New Zealand.

The extremely expressive nature with combination of red and black fruits, 14% alcohol, high, refreshing acidity and medium and quite fine tannins point to a New World continental climate and Central Otago, New Zealand in particular. The moderate ruby colour is consistent with the thicker skins of this high UV location and all further confirm Central Otago.

QUESTION 4

a) Tempranillo

Wine 11 - La Mancha

Wine 12 - Ribera del Duero

The moderate ruby colour of Wine 11 with simple raspberry and strawberry notes suggests either Merlot or Tempranillo. Wine 12 with its conversely black fruit notes of dark plum and blueberry is more consistent with the diversity of Tempranillo over Merlot.

The 13.5% alcohol of Wine 11 contrasting the 15% of Wine 12 shows the different styles and climates and versatility of the variety. Wine 11 with its simple fruit nature, moderate tannins, medium acidity, unoaked and quite herbaceous style with a short finish point to a large generic origin such as La Mancha .

Wine 12, has a deeper more opaque colour, black fruited profile, higher alcohol 15% and high, tart acidity more consistent with an extreme continental, higher altitude and higher diurnal range location and suggests Ribera del Duero.

b)

Wine 11 has a medium ruby colour, medium and quite coarse tannins and quite a dilute profile suggesting grapes sourced from a high-yielding, large geographical location, The emphasis on red fruit over structure suggests no real sorting and short fermentation, likely around 8 days in stainless steel at 28-30°C, with cultured yeast. The preservation of these simple red fruit characters indicate subsequent ageing also in inert vessel, likely for a maximum of 4-5 months. The pristine, one-dimensional nature points to cold stabilisation, fining and filtration to give the simple and uniform style.

Wine 12, in contrast, shows a much higher intensity and concentration of black fruit suggesting grapes sourced from selected, lower yielding and probably older vines. It has more colour and firmer tannins than Wine 11 indicating a longer fermentation, up to three weeks with more frequent extraction by pumpovers and lower temperatures, 26-28°C and possibly with natural yeasts. The firm yet quite polymerised tannins indicate a possible post fermentation maceration and the quite fine toast indicates ageing in French oak rather than the inert vessel of Wine 11 and for a longer period, minimum 12 months with some new, 20%. The fine structure and quite complex and long finish suggests a possible bottling without fining or filtration.

c) Wine 11 is a simple, one-dimensional, acceptable quality wine. It has very light red fruit flavours, slightly green in style, very modest tannins, no real complexity from any oak or spice and a short finish. The palate is well balanced between the 13.5% alcohol, medium acidity and light fruit intensity but overall is quite dilute in nature suggesting an acceptable quality, inexpensive style.

Wine 12, in contrast is a very good quality, old vine wine. It is deeper in colour, more concentrated and more structured than Wine 11 with high, rather than moderate tannins which also are much finer and also shows a higher level of refreshing acidity. There is much more complexity than Wine 11, too, with noticeable vanilla and toast from French oak ageing in contrast to the lack of oak on Wine 11. The finish too is quite long rather than the shorter one of Wine 11. It does not have the extra length and weight of the very best Ribera del Duero wines but is clearly a much higher quality example than Wine 11.

Wine 11 with its simple one-dimensional style and short finish is a high volume, inexpensive, entry-level style retailing for around \$10. It will, therefore appeal to a mass market audience and

very price conscious consumer looking for red wine at a bargain price point. Wine 12, on the other hand, is more concentrated, complex and structured than Wine 11 with oak and terroir notes and will retail at a higher price, likely \$40. It will therefore appeal to a much narrower audience than Wine 11, those looking for more premium quality and age worthy wines.

It is a complex, oak aged style that could also be aimed at adventurous consumers of wines as diverse as Cru Bourgeois Bordeaux, Northern Rhone Syrah or premium, Argentine Malbec. The higher price and more complex style mean it is suited more to Independent Wine Merchants and premium restaurants rather than distribution in large supermarkets, convenience stores and fast food chains for Wine 11.